artillery support and limited ammunition, would be overrun sooner rather than later.

After a while, a despondent GOC was back on the line. He had conveyed his own and Dalvi's assessment to the BGS IV Corps, Brigadier K. K. Singh. The BGS is the hub around which the entire Corps HQ technically functions. Despite everything Prasad said on the phone, Singh was adamant that Kaul's orders were sacrosanct. He did, however, offer to try and contact the general who was said to be suffering from pulmonary oedema and was bedridden in Delhi. The BGS then said Division HQ and the brigade should not panic, as it was unlikely that the Chinese would do anything big. This was to be the last communication between 4 Division and IV Corps.

Dalvi was getting more and more frustrated and upset. When he got this last call, present in the mess with him were the divisional signals officer, Lieutenant Colonel K. K. Tewari; the brigade major, Major Rex Kharbanda; the DQ, Major Pereira; the OC mortar battery, Major Balraj Nijjar; the Intelligence officer, Captain Tushar Gupta; the signals officer (Sparrow) Captain Lakshman Singh; and Captain H. S. Talwar who had wandered down from 17 Para Field gun position to Brigade HQ. Unmindful of the fact that all the officers could hear every detail of the conversation between himself and the GOC, Brigadier Dalvi said words to the effect: 'I can no longer stand by and watch the massacre of my men. It is time that some senior officer took a firm stand. This is no longer a case of trying to bluff the Chinese by sitting under their noses. If a scapegoat is wanted, I am willing to offer myself and am prepared to accept the consequences, and resign my commission.'

Dalvi's outburst had the strange effect of causing Niranjan Prasad to break down. The general turned fatalistic and said he too had enough, and he might as well go down with the brigade the next day. He said he would stay and die with the men. This was perhaps Prasad's moment of truth. In the absence of Kaul, he was the officiating corps commander. Being fully aware of the situation on the ground he could have concurred and ordered a withdrawal. But yet again he chose to look over his shoulder and ask for instructions. Maybe by then it was already too late, for even as the two most senior commanders on the ground openly expressed their impotence and helplessness, Chinese infiltration parties had already started preparing to ford the Nam Ka Chu and come up behind the Indian positions.